Yasmin Busran-Lao

Yasmin Busran-Lao is one of the most quietly consequential figures in Philippine peacebuilding, a woman whose fingerprints are on landmark agreements, grassroots organizations, and national policy shifts that have reshaped how the country understands both peace and Muslim womanhood.

Over more than 25 years, she has championed **women's rights, gender justice, and sustainable peace** in Muslim Mindanao, doing so not as a bystander or commentator but as a practitioner, a negotiator, and an organizer who worked from barangay halls to national peace panels.

She is perhaps best known for her role as a member of the **Government Peace Negotiating Panel** during talks with the Moro Islamic Liberation Front (MILF), a position that placed her at the heart of one of the Philippines' most complex and historic diplomatic processes.

Her contributions directly fed into the **2014 Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro (CAB)**, a peace treaty celebrated internationally for its unusually strong, gender-sensitive provisions.

Contents

1 Early Life and Background
2 Education
3 Career and Institutional Contributions
    3.1 Grassroots and Civil Society Leadership
    3.2 Government Peace Negotiations
    3.3 National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
    3.4 National Politics
4 Personal Philosophy
5 Recognition and Awards
6 Legacy
7 See Also
8 References

Early Life and Background

Yasmin Busran-Lao grew up in Muslim Mindanao at a time when the region was anything but peaceful.

During the **1970s siege of Marawi City** under Martial Law, her family was among the thousands forced to flee their homes, becoming *bakwit*, the local term for internally displaced persons caught between government troops and Moro rebels.

To escape the crossfire, her family crossed Lanao Lake by pump boat, seeking refuge among her father's relatives.

That experience of sudden displacement, of leaving behind everything familiar in the middle of the night, stayed with her.

Growing up amid structural poverty and recurring armed conflict gave Busran-Lao something that no classroom could fully teach: a visceral understanding of what conflict does to ordinary people, and in particular to women and children who rarely appear in the headlines but bear the heaviest burden of war.

Later in life, witnessing the "all-out-war" of 2000 and its wave of displacement would further sharpen her resolve to advocate for the most vulnerable in her community.

Education

Busran-Lao built an academic foundation that was, from the beginning, deliberately cross-disciplinary.

She earned a **Bachelor of Arts in Psychology** from Far Eastern University, graduating *magna cum laude*, a distinction that reflected not just academic ability but the kind of focused, disciplined thinking she would later bring to policy and advocacy work.

She then pursued a **Master's degree in Clinical Counselling Psychology** at the Ateneo de Manila University, developing a framework for understanding trauma, community behavior, and the psychological dimensions of conflict.

Knowing that culture and religion would be central to any meaningful work in Muslim Mindanao, she also undertook specialized coursework in **Islamic Studies** at the University of the Philippines Diliman, and in **Muslim Personal Laws** at Mindanao State University.

That combination, behavioral science layered with deep knowledge of Islamic jurisprudence and cultural context, is precisely what made her effective in spaces where most outsiders struggled to connect.

Career and Institutional Contributions

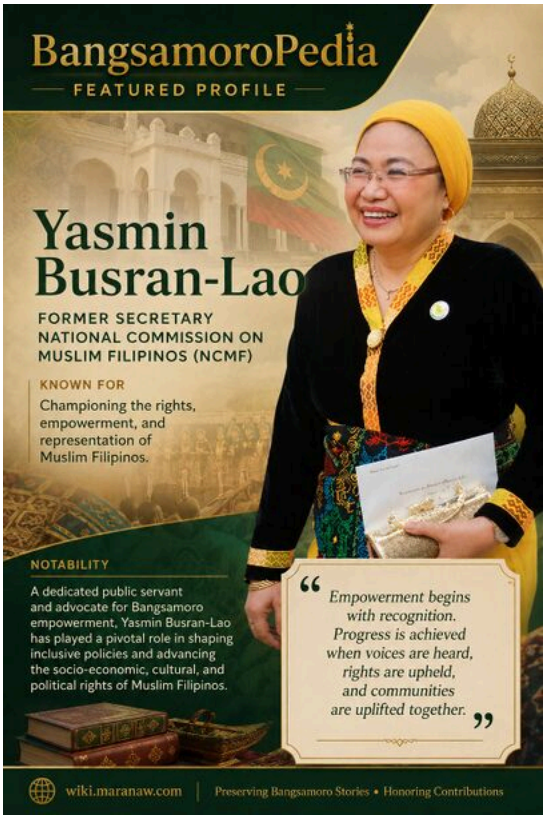
Grassroots and Civil Society Leadership

Long before she sat at government negotiating tables, Busran-Lao was building institutions from the ground up.

She founded the **Al-Mujadilah Development Foundation, Inc. (AMDF)**, based in Marawi City, naming it after the 58th Surah of the Qur'an, *Al-Mujadila*, which translates roughly as "The Woman Who Pleads" or "She Who Disputes."

The name was not accidental.

Yasmin Busran-Lao



Full Name	Yasmin Busran-Lao
Nationality	Filipino
Region	Muslim Mindanao, Philippines
Known For	Peace advocacy, gender justice, women's rights in the Bangsamoro
Education	BA Psychology, *magna cum laude*, Far Eastern University; MA Clinical Counselling Psychology, Ateneo de Manila University; Islamic Studies, University of the Philippines Diliman; Muslim Personal Laws, Mindanao State University
Organizations	Al-Mujadilah Development Foundation, Inc. (AMDF); Nisa Ul-Haqq Fi Bangsamoro
Government Roles	Member, Government Peace Negotiating Panel (MILF Talks); Secretary, National Commission on

AMDF was deliberately designed as a space where Muslim women's voices could be amplified in discussions about social justice, community peacebuilding, and reproductive health.

Under her leadership, AMDF produced pioneering educational materials that are still referenced today, including a *Primer on the Code of Muslim Personal Laws* and a *CEDAW Primer* translated into four Moro dialects, making international human rights frameworks accessible to communities that had long been excluded from those conversations.

	Muslim Filipinos (NCMF); Presidential Assistant for Muslim Affairs
Awards	2005 Benigno S. Aquino Jr. Fellowship Award for Public Service; *Marie Claire* "Women of Substance" Top 25

She also co-founded **Nisa Ul-Haqq Fi Bangsamoro** (Women for Truth and Justice in the Bangsamoro), a network of Muslim women leaders that conducts community-based research to push for policies that align the core teachings of the Qur'an with modern human rights principles.

Both organizations represent her conviction that lasting change doesn't come from the top down; it grows from within communities, when people are given the tools to advocate for themselves.

Government Peace Negotiations

Busran-Lao's most internationally recognized contribution came through her appointment to the **Government Peace Negotiating Panel** for the talks with the Moro Islamic Liberation Front (MILF).

Working alongside Chief Negotiator Miriam Coronel-Ferrer, she made it her mission to ensure that the resulting peace framework wasn't just a political document but one that explicitly recognized women's security needs and guaranteed their meaningful participation in the Bangsamoro transition.

That work bore fruit in the **2014 Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro**, a treaty that drew international attention for its gender-sensitive provisions, widely regarded as a model for inclusive peacebuilding.

National Commission on Muslim Filipinos

She also served as the **Cabinet-level Secretary of the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF)** and as **Presidential Assistant for Muslim Affairs** under President Benigno Aquino III.

In those roles, she oversaw cultural, social, and economic policies affecting Muslim minorities across the country, bridging the gap between Malacañang and communities that had long felt disconnected from the machinery of national government.

National Politics

In 2010, Busran-Lao was selected by the Liberal Party to join its national senatorial slate.

Her campaign carried a clear and deliberate message: that politics could be practiced differently, without the traditional machinery of money, dynasty, or patronage, and that ordinary citizens deserved to be the spokespersons of their own political futures.

While her Senate bid did not succeed, it reflected her broader belief that political reform requires new kinds of voices and new modes of participation.

Personal Philosophy

At the core of everything Busran-Lao does is a conviction that **social justice and women's rights are not foreign concepts imposed on Muslim communities, but principles already present in Islam itself.**

She has consistently refused the framing that pits Islamic tradition against international human rights frameworks, arguing instead that the Qur'an, read carefully and honestly, already calls for equity, fairness, and the protection of the vulnerable.

For her, the challenge has never been to convince Muslim communities to adopt "outside" values. The challenge has been to help those communities rediscover and articulate values they already hold.

She is also a firm believer in grassroots-driven democracy, insisting that real political reform only happens when ordinary people have platforms to name their own needs and lead their own solutions.

Recognition and Awards

Recognition	Details
Global Peace Milestone	Contributed to the Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro (CAB, 2014), internationally praised as a landmark treaty for gender-inclusive peacebuilding.
2005 Benigno S. Aquino Jr. Fellowship Award for Public Service	Awarded by the Benigno S. Aquino Foundation and the U.S. Embassy in recognition of her work with marginalized communities.
***Marie Claire* "Women of Substance" Top 25**	Named among the top 25 women of substance in the Philippines for her pioneering contributions to Muslim women's rights.
Policy Network Collaboration	Collaborated with the Change Politics Movement, the Human Development Network, and INCITEGov to advance inclusive democratic governance.

Legacy

Yasmin Busran-Lao's most enduring contribution may be a shift in narrative.

For too long, Moro women were cast in Philippine public discourse as passive figures, victims of conflict, silent presences in a story dominated by men with guns or men at desks.

She helped dismantle that framing systematically, through organizations she built, agreements she shaped, educational materials she produced, and coalitions she formed.

She showed that Muslim women could be architects of peace rather than simply its beneficiaries, and that faith, far from being an obstacle to gender justice, could be its most powerful foundation.

Her legacy lives in the gender provisions of the CAB, in the women's networks she helped establish across Mindanao, and in the countless advocates she mentored who continue her work in communities she once organized.

See Also

- Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro

- Moro Islamic Liberation Front
- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- Al-Mujadilah Development Foundation, Inc.
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Miriam Coronel-Ferrer
- Women's Rights in the Philippines

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